

THE ONE I FAILED AND THE ONE I PASSED

The PM loop, both times

I interviewed at Microsoft twice. The first time I was rejected. The second time I got the offer with no product management experience at all.

Here are both loops, with every round I remember, what I was asked, and what I'd do to prepare for each one.

1 The interview I failed

This was 2016 or 2017, near the end of school, for a software engineering role. I wasn't too pressed about it. I already had close to ten offers, from Intel, Northrop Grumman, Eli Lilly, IBM, JPL and others, so Microsoft would have just been a plus.

Nobody asked me a single behavioral question, and those were my strength after all the interviews I'd done. It was programming question after programming question. The one I remember is: can you write the binary search tree of the word computer?

The problem was easy. Coding just wasn't my strong suit, and I didn't like it much. My degree was computer engineering and I spent more of my time on the hardware side: VHDL, VLSI, circuits. On the software side I knew data structures and Big O as concepts, but solving problems on the fly wasn't straightforward for me.

I didn't do a good job, and I didn't get the job.

EXAMPLE

Before the loop, ask the recruiter: "Can you walk me through what each round covers? Is any of it live coding?"

WHY THIS MATTERS: every question in that loop was a programming question, so the rejection said nothing about the behavioral side, which was my strength. A few years later the PM loop started with behavioral questions.

2 Doing both when companies hire for one

In 2017, a computer engineering degree made you a jack of all trades and a master of none. I did software and I did hardware, but most companies only hired you for one. So most of my interviews swung hard to one side, and it didn't matter that I had experience in both.

I tried to use having both as my edge. I'd tell interviewers I do software and I do hardware, and that the two together are where the industry is going. I still got pushed hard down one path. Today that's truer than ever, with companies like Apple making the software work really well because they own the hardware too.

EXAMPLE

If your background covers two things, look for the roles that need both, and say both in the first minute. My PM pitch opened with hardware validation and went straight to the Alexa skills I built in Java on weekends.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the both-sides background that didn't matter in engineering interviews is the whole point of my PM pitch, and that pitch got me sent to a Microsoft recruiter.

3 The loop I passed, and its shape

This was right before COVID. Five interviews, about forty minutes to an hour each, four to five hours in one day.

It wasn't a normal loop. A bunch of people flew in, each candidate sat in a separate room, and the interviewers went from room to room. I met senior engineers and senior PMs, from teams hiring for different roles.

The rounds I remember were behavioral questions, estimation questions, a case question and a coding round, and the coding round came last.

EXAMPLE

Ask the recruiter: "How many rounds are there, how long is each one, and who will I be meeting?" It's a normal question, and the answer tells you how to pace a four to five hour day.

WHY THIS MATTERS: my last round was coding, my weakest, after hours of other interviews. If you know the order ahead of time, you know where to save your energy.

4 Round type one, behavioral

Why do you want to be at Microsoft? Tell me about yourself. Why should we hire you?

Don't treat these as the easy ones. The way I see it, we're all salesmen, and the thing we're selling is ourselves and our effort. So attach a dollar number to yourself: "I'm this person, I'm bringing you this value, and here's the dollar number attached to me."

People also asked why I wanted to move from engineering to product. This is close to what I said:

"Engineering is great. You get to solve problems on the ground and you get to focus on why things work. But I wanted to understand more of the what and the how. Why are we doing this, who are we doing this for, why does the customer care, what's the dollar value attached to this? As an engineer, your scope is really set by what your manager tells you, and you don't really know how that impacts everything all the way up."

EXAMPLE

Write your reason for the switch in three parts, the way I did: what your current role is great at, what it doesn't let you see, and what you want to work on instead.

WHY THIS MATTERS: I was trying to escape my job at the time, and my answer still opened with "engineering is great." Every line after that is about the work I wanted to do next.

5 Round type two, the case

Mine was: how would you design an elevator for blind people?

Don't jump straight into features like buttons, braille and audio. You have to first understand the problem, and there are so many questions you should ask before you dive into solving it.

Who are we designing it for? Where is the building, and what kind of building is it? What do blind riders do today, and where does that fail? What matters most: safety, speed, independence or cost? Are we fixing an elevator that exists or building a new one?

The questions help you frame the context. Once you have the context, you can target who your specific audience is and what problem you're trying to solve.

EXAMPLE

Practice on anything in the room. Say "design a better kettle" out loud, then ask five questions before you suggest a single feature.

WHY THIS MATTERS: anybody can become a PM, genuinely, if you really put your heart into it. A lot of it should come to you as common sense, and asking before solving is a habit you can practice this week.

6 Round type three, coding

Mine was: write a Sudoku game from scratch.

Coding was my weakest point. I programmed it end to end, and the interviewer said that even though I figured it out, or we figured it out together, my coding skills were raw.

EXAMPLE

Pick your weakest round before the loop and practice it until you can finish a problem end to end, even slowly. Talk out loud as you go, so the interviewer can help you the way mine did.

WHY THIS MATTERS: my coding was called raw, and about a week later I got a call saying they liked me and wanted to give me an offer.

7 What I used to prepare

The book Cracking the PM Interview, by Gayle Laakmann McDowell and Jackie Bavaro, and a lot of YouTube videos of case studies.

EXAMPLE

Watch three case walkthroughs this week. Pause each one after the question, give your own answer out loud, then press play and compare.

WHY THIS MATTERS: that book and its framework are what helped me understand what I needed to solve when the elevator question came up.

8 What I wore

I always overdress: a blazer, a turtleneck and suit pants. Some people wore something casual. I like to carry myself properly, and I feel really good when I do.

EXAMPLE

Dress how you feel best, even if the people around you show up casual.

WHY THIS MATTERS: you'll be interviewing for four to five hours, so wear something you'll still feel good in by the last round.

I failed the first one. In the second one my coding was called raw, and I got the offer anyway.

If you've failed a loop, write down what each round tested. That tells you what to work on, and what kind of role to try for next.